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Aristotle and Religious Theory

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Richard - Aristotle and Religious Theory - JCRT 1.3
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Theology has ended,¹ and religious life proliferates.² No longer presuming to discern a divine intention written in the plethora of signs that once marked religious space and time as a space and time of divine visitation, we are left with the signs themselves 'an elevated scroll or cup, bodies leaping and jerking, a circle of standing stones' and the bare fact that, for 'us' at least, they advance a common claim to the name of religion.³ Of course, this bare fact is historically and geographically located. The end of theology means that we cannot start from an assumed *a priori* category of 'religious experience,' and straightaway begin to elucidate its endless varieties. In fact, any attempt to understand the common claim to religion would have to begin with a critique of the implicit rules that 'we' students of religion, relying on the assumed *a priori* perception of missionaries and ethnographers, have used to collect the specific array of signs that we call 'religious.' Thus, it would locate the process within what Carl A. Raschke has called 'the Roman epoch'⁴ and what Jacques Derrida has called 'Latinity.'⁵ It would also note peculiar modifications of the Latin notion of *religio* arising out of contact between various non-European peoples and the European colonialists who believed they had identified, isolated, and understood the word. These peoples they often imagined to be the antitype of their own religious purity, the embodiment of their own disavowed sin. In the end, however, our own attempt to understand "religion," like that of the Romans and the European colonialists, will have recourse to an explicit or implicit *theory*.

One can *not* deny it, which means that the most one can do is to deny it. Any discourse that would be opposed to it would, in effect, always succumb to the figure or the logic of denial (denegation). Such would be the place where, before and after all the Enlightenments in the world, reason, critique, science, tele-technoscience, philosophy, thought in general, retain the *same* source as religion in general.⁶

¹"Theology has ended" here primarily refers to Carl A. Raschke's usage of the phrase "end of theology," the most extended discussion of which occurs in Raschke, C., *The Alchemy of the Word: Language and the End of Theology*. (Missoula, MT: Scholars Press, 1979). Since the publication of this work, Raschke ("Theology, Hermeneutics, and the Shattering of Foundations," *Encounter* [Autumn, 1982], 401-407) has summarized his use of the phrase as designating "not the cessation of what might be loosely imagined as 'theological' conversation, but abstention from any 'theologizing' that recurs to privileged representations such as kerygma, doctrine, or even 'God' in the doctrinaire meaning of the word." On the other hand, the word "end" in *Alchemy of the Word* implies the notion of fulfillment as well as the notion of termination, just it reminds us that "destruction" or "deconstruction" is not so much about sheer iconoclasm as it is about a dismantling that frees what has hitherto remained unthought within the ontotheological tradition.

²This seeming paradox - the proliferation of religious life and academic chatter about it, along with the philosophical disenfranchisement of theological discourse - is the starting point for Charles E. Winquist's reflection on the critical vocation of the theologian after the end of theology in *Epiphanies of Darkness: Deconstruction in Theology*. (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1986). Winquist insists that a "surplus of unsaid meaning calling from the darkness of primary religious experience" (p. 19) pressures thinking toward a transgression of the delimitations that "semantic anxiety" has imposed on theology and its successor, the academic study of religion."

³Raschke, C., "Meaning and Saying In Religion: Beyond Language Games," *Harvard Theological Review*, 67 (2): 79-116; 1974.

⁴Raschke, C., "The Image of the Beast, or Theology and the Thought of Difference," *Journal of the American Academy of Religion, Thematic Studies*, XLIX (1): 109-126.

⁵Derrida, J., "Faith and Knowledge: The Two Sources of 'Religion' at the Limits of Reason Alone," In J. Derrida and G. Vattimo (eds.) *Religion*. (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1998), p. 29.

⁶*Ibid.*, p. 59.

Saying and Being

The god and another

Self-Movement

Just as when one contemplates the painting in the picture as being a likeness, and without having [at that moment] seen the actual Corsicus, contemplates it as a likeness of Corsicus, and in that case the experience involved in this contemplation of it [as relative] is different from what one has when he contemplates it simply as a painted figure ' [so in the case of memory we have the analogous difference, for], of the objects in the soul, the one [the unrelated object] presents itself simply as a thought, but the other [the related object], just because, as in the painting, it is a likeness, presents itself as a mnemonic token.⁷

The Theology of Theory

Thinking in itself deals with that which is best in itself, and that which is thinking in the fullest sense with that which is best in the fullest sense. An thought thinks on itself because it shares the nature of the object of thought; for it becomes an object of thought in coming into contact with and thinking its objects, so that thought and object of thought are the same.⁸

Notes

Alan Jay Richard, Ph.D., an independent researcher, is principal investigator for 'Formative Research on Cocaine Use among Hispanics in the Southwestern United States,' a three-year, multimillion dollar research effort funded by the National Institutes on Drug Abuse. He has served as co-investigator on a number of other federal research grants in the areas of HIV risk, social networks, and addiction. He has published over 70 articles in peer-reviewed journals in the fields of religion, ethics, sociology, and psychology. Besides religious theory, his scholarly and research interests include emotional attachment, affective neuroscience, addiction, sociology of religion, American religion, and the erotic imagination.

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⁷*De Memoria* I, 450b 26 - 451a 4.

⁸*Metaphysics* XII.VII, 1072b: 18-23.